

READER TIP:

There are plenty of repairs novices can do with basic tools. Changing your alternator and fan belts is relatively easy. I saved \$100 easily by replacing my own alternator, and it's only secured on the motor with a few bolts. Changing your own oil, transmission fluid, and performing a radiator flush are all things that can be done by following videos on YouTube.

—Derrick, MI

3. USE COUPONS

I don't know about you, but I constantly receive coupons in the mail from our car manufacturer and several local repair shops. These coupons always offer major discounts on oil changes, tire rotations, brake checks, and other similar tune-up jobs, and range anywhere from 15-40% off!

If you're not loyal to any one shop, or haven't found a trustworthy car mechanic yet, you may want to take advantage of these coupons and try a few places before deciding on the one you like most. Don't forget to check [Groupon.com](https://www.groupon.com) for any specials they might be running as well.

4. KNOW YOUR PRICES

Regardless of who your mechanic is, research the repair in question before settling on a price. [RepairPal.com](https://www.repairpal.com) allows you to find the average price of a repair in your area so you know for sure you're not being duped, and can get a general idea of what things cost before spending any money.

Depending on the repair in question, you may be able to shop around for parts, watch a YouTube tutorial on how to install them, and save a little money on the final bill. Or, you could just pay your mechanic the labor it takes for him to do it at his shop. We were able to buy tires much cheaper online than from the garage, and our mechanic didn't mind at all.